> power consolidated in Afghanistan and that in the event it will be vital for us to ensure Pakistan's survival as a buffer between us and the Soviet power.[31]

Many in India understood, if not sympathised with, Pakistan's covert campaign against Soviet forces in Afghanistan. Opening a dialogue with Pakistan, from this perspective, was as much an exercise in signaling India's willingness to cooperate with Zia, as it was to contain change in South Asia's balance of power using diplomatic means. Sathe, and his Pakistani counterpart, Agha Shahi, undertook repeated visits during this period to discuss modalities of such cooperation. Parallel to India's outreach to Pakistan, New Delhi was getting feelers from Moscow and Pakistani separatists to exploit the situation and finish 1971's 'unfinished business'. In 1982, Fikryat Tabeev, the then Soviet ambassador to Afghanistan told J. N. Dixit, India's new ambassador to Kabul, to seriously mull a full-scale war against Pakistan in order to 'take back' the whole of Kashmir, as Rawalpindi focused on Afghanistan. Unaffected by Baloch and Pashtun requests for support to reignite insurgencies across Pakistan, Gandhi put a firm veto on Tabeev's 'adventurous' proposal citing concerns of global condemnation and an undesirable Chinese military intervention in Kashmir.[32] She even refused to organise a meeting between Ghaffar Khan and Brezhnev to discuss Pashtunistan, forcing Ghaffar Khan, in protest, to cancel his visit to Delhi for medical treatment in March 1982.[33] Khan bitterly blamed Gandhi for betraying the Pashtuns, just like Nehru had done, and for having no *raham* (mercy or in this context, can also imply sympathy) for the Pashtunistan issue.

Apart from engaging with Pakistan, India sought better relations with the US and UK, and tried building an international consensus to reach a 'political solution' (something that Afghan leader Babrak Karmal also recommended) to end the Afghan imbroglio and ensure an early Soviet exit. Soon after abstaining at the UNGA vote, Gandhi, along with British Foreign Secretary Lord Carrington, publicly stated that 'no country is justified in entering another country'.[34] London had been working behind the scenes with a cautious (about relations with Moscow) New Delhi to pursue a plan to create a 'neutral' Afghanistan,[35] involving declaration of permanent neutrality, but to limited effect (even though Pakistan was also in agreement with the idea of a neutral Afghanistan).[36]